

St. John Chrysostom on Brotherly Love

How is love born in the human soul? Love is the fruit of virtue. But **love**, in turn, **begets virtue**. And this is how it is done: The virtuous man does not prefer money to love for his fellow man. He is not a grudge. He is not unfair. He is not a bad doctor. He endures everything with mental bravery. From these comes love.

That love is born from virtue is revealed by the Lord's words: "When wickedness abounds, love will grow cold" (Mat. 24:12). And the fact that **virtue is born from love** is revealed by Paul's words: "**Whoever loves another has kept all the commandments of God**" (Rom. 13:8).

One of the two, then, is required, either love or virtue. Anyone who has one will definitely have the other. And on the contrary: He who does not love will also do evil; and he who does evil does not love. Love, therefore, let's try to acquire, because it is a fortress that protects us from all evil.

The apostle did not simply say "love," but "**pursue love**" (1 Cor. 14:1), as a great struggle is required to obtain it. Love runs fast and disappears, because many things of this world destroy it. Let us pursue her, let us constantly run after her, to capture her, before she can leave us.

Paul also tells us the reasons why we should love one another, saying: "Show with affection your brotherly love for others" (Rom. 12:10). He wants to say: You are brothers, and therefore you should have brotherly love between you. This is what Moses said to those Jews who quarreled in Egypt: "Why are you quarreling? You are brothers" (Ex. 2:13).

It is noteworthy that the apostle, while advising Christians in their relations with each other to show affection and brotherly love to one another, when referring to the relations of Christians with unbelievers, says something different: "As far as it depends on you, live peaceably with all men" (Rom. 12:18).

In the case of unbelievers, that is, he asks us not to quarrel with them, not to hate them, not to despise them, while **in the case of our Christian brothers, he asks for additional affection, philanthropy, sincere and genuine love, warm and permanent love.**

But how will love be permanent? The apostle also indicates this to us, saying: "**Compete to see who will honor the other more**" (Rom. 12:10). This is how love is created and lasts forever. For, in truth, there is no better means of preserving love than to grant the other the primacy of honor. This is how love becomes lively and mutual appreciation deep.

Beyond honor, we still need to show interest in each other's problems, **because the combination of honor and interest creates the warmest love.** It is not enough to love only with the heart, but these two are also necessary, honor and interest, which are manifestations of love, but also conditions. They are born of love, but they also give birth to love.